

THE GREEN WAVE

A Stagnant Revolution

The green revolution has been the country's best advertised success story, leading to the dramatic transformation from an international basket-case to a model held out to others by such critical institutions as the World Bank. But gone suddenly is the buoyancy. Foodgrain production has not increased for three successive years. And this year, once again, production will be lower than the 132 million tonne hit four years ago, in 1978-79.

Meanwhile there are over 50 million more mouths to feed. No more the proud talk of self-sufficiency in food. Instead, for the second successive year, the Government has been forced to import wheat. Purchases abroad of 4.75 million tonne since summer last year have cost the equivalent of almost Rs 1,000 crore in dollars. Food has suddenly become a major national problem. Agricultural technology is another worrying factor. According to some scientists, Indian agriculture is not losing momentum. But they also admit that a new technological breakthrough will be some time in coming.

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Research Institute (IRRI) that raised the paddy yield from one tonne per hectare to four tonne.

Punjab became a state where the green revolution saw massive economic growth. Agriculture still accounts for one-third of the state GDP and the state leads the world, producing about 10 tonne of wheat and paddy per hectare in a year. The tide turned in the mid-'80s with stagnant productivity, rising expenses and declining net incomes. The water-guzzling paddy, now grown on a whopping 66 lakh acres, has led to an ecological imbalance, with the ground water table falling by one metre annually in some of the most fertile zones of the state.

Yet, the Punjab peasant is still imbued with a deep-rooted craving for reinventing farming. A new crop of enterprising farmers has scripted trail-blazing success stories by making a break from traditional crops to low-volume and high-value crops. One such man is 42-year-old Sukhpal Singh Bhullar who replaced the traditional crops of wheat, cotton and paddy on his 63-acre holding in Ghuman Kalan



GREEN FINGERS: A Ludhiana farmer reaps a bumper wheat crop in 1968

17 m

tonne of wheat was harvested in India in 1967-68, 7 m more than in 1966-67

75 m

tonne of wheat was produced in 2006 from 146 lakh hectare of land

village of Bhatinda district, with vegetables, fruits and flowers. By combining innovative farming practices with ingenious improvisation and hands-on marketing, Bhullar has been reaping rich profits and plaudits in the state's backwaters where most farmers are in heavy debt due to the repeated failure of cotton crop.

His net income from a *kinnow* (a citrus fruit) orchard is Rs 3.5 lakh per acre—five times more than from wheat and cotton. "I earn more from one acre of high-value crops than from 10 acre under traditional crops," says Bhullar, known among his peers as a "four-to-eleven" farmer for the long hours he puts in. While his aged father started farming with camel-driven tillers, Bhullar's 15-year-old son, Vattandeep Singh, chips in with Internet-based marketing of citrus crop outside the state. Clearly, Punjab needs more such trailblazers to re-seed the green revolution of food grain into a rainbow revolution of high-value crops. ■